(Brazil, in fact, took its case against US farm subsidies and EU sugar subsidies to the WTO, which ruled in Brazil's favour, suggesting that the WTO, far from an instrument of US or European 'imperialism', is an effective instrument of the transnational state.) What appear as international struggles for global hegemony or struggles of the South against the North are better seen as struggles by emerging transnational capitalists and elites outside of the original transatlantic and trilateral core to break into the ranks of the global elite and develop a capacity to influence global policy formation, manage global crises, and participate in ongoing global restructuring. The BRICS' national economic strategy is structured around global integration. Nationalism becomes a strategy for seeking space in the global capitalist order in association with transnational capital from abroad.

Those who posit growing international conflict between the traditional core countries and rising powers in the former Third World point most often to China and its alleged conflict with the United States over global influence. Geopolitical analysis as conjunctural analysis must be informed by structural analysis. The policies of the Chinese (as well as those of the other BRICS states) have been aimed at integration into global production chains in association with transnational capital. Already by 2005 China's stock of FDI to GDP was 36%, compared to 1.5% for Japan and 5% for India, with half of its foreign sales and nearly a third of its industrial output generated by transnational corporations. Moreover, the giant Chinese companies – ranging from the oil and chemical sectors to automobiles, electronics, telecommunications, and finance – have associated with TNCs from around the world in the form of mergers and acquisitions, shared stock, cross-investment, joint ventures, subcontracting, and so on, both inside China and around the world. Inside China, for instance, some 80% of large-scale supermarkets had merged with foreign companies by 2008.

There is simply no evidence of 'Chinese' companies in fierce rivalry with 'US' and other 'Western' companies over international control. Rather, the picture is one of competition among transnational conglomerates, as discussed earlier, which integrate Chinese companies. That Chinese firms have more secure access to the Chinese state than other firms does not imply the state conflict that observers posit, since these firms are integrated into transnational capitalist networks and access the Chinese state on behalf of the amalgamated interests of the groups into which they are inserted. Similarly, these same observers point to a growing US trade deficit and an inverse accumulation of international reserves by China and then conclude that the two states are locked in competition over international hegemony. But we cannot possibly understand US–Chinese trade